

Northwind Robotics

Warehouse picking automation for mid-size distribution centers

Seed round - \$4.0M - August 2026

The Problem

US warehouses ran 490,000 unfilled picking roles in 2025 (BLS).

Turnover in manual picking averages 46% annually.

Existing robotic arms cost \$310K installed - out of reach below
50,000 sq ft of floorspace.

Operators pay \$71K fully loaded per picker per year.

Our Solution

The NW-1 arm: a retrofit picking cell that mounts to existing conveyor lines in under four hours.

Force-feedback gripper handles mixed-SKU totes without retooling.

Installed cost \$148K, roughly half the incumbent price point.

Runs on standard 240V; no facility rewiring required.

How It Works

Vision stack trained on 2.1M labeled tote images from pilot sites.

Pick success rate 98.4% across 14 SKU categories (internal testing).

Cycle time 4.2 seconds vs 6.1 seconds for a human picker.

Edge inference on-device; no cloud dependency during operation.

Market

TAM: \$12B - global warehouse automation hardware, 2030.

SAM: 21,400 US distribution centers between 20K and 50K sq ft.

At 3 arms per site and \$148K ASP, that is a \$9.5B serviceable market.

Beachhead: third-party logistics operators in the US Midwest.

Traction

Two paid pilots converted to three-year contracts in Q2 2026.

Midwest Fulfillment Co - 6 arms deployed, \$890K contract value.

Cardinal 3PL - 4 arms deployed, \$592K contract value.

\$1.48M of contracted revenue; \$310K recognized to date.

Letter of intent from a third operator for 12 arms, pending pilot.

Business Model

Hardware sale at \$148K per arm plus \$18K/year service contract.

Current gross margin 31%; modeled at 52% at 500 units/year.

Payback for the customer: 14 months at current labor rates.

Net revenue retention 100% (both pilot accounts expanded).

Team

Dr. Elena Vasquez, CEO - previously Principal Robotics Engineer at a public warehouse automation firm; shipped two arm platforms.

Marcus Chen, CTO - 11 years in computer vision; PhD, CMU.

Priya Raman, VP Operations - scaled contract manufacturing at a consumer hardware company from 2K to 80K units/year.

Open role: VP Sales. No commercial hire to date.

Competition

Incumbent A: \$310K installed, targets 100K+ sq ft facilities.

Incumbent B: European, well funded, shipping a comparable arm into EU logistics since Q4 2025; no US presence announced.

Two provisional patents filed on the gripper mechanism.

No composition or method patents granted to date.

The Ask

Raising \$4.0M on a \$18M post-money SAFE, 20% discount.

\$1.6M committed; seeking a lead for the remaining \$2.4M.

Use of proceeds: \$1.7M engineering, \$1.1M contract manufacturing NRE, \$0.8M go-to-market, \$0.4M working capital.

18 months of runway to a Series A at 40 arms deployed.

Contract manufacturer not yet selected; actuator supply agreement unsigned as of this deck.